

|1997| ARUNDHATI ROY'S BOOKER PRIZE

The Mistress of the Pen

Roy's win sanctifies a new language, not the exotic, but the contemporary

The God of Small Things

ARUNDHATI ROY

Carmen Callil, co-founder of the feminist publishing house, Virago, was a Booker judge in 1996. Thankfully, the next year, she wasn't, because at the end of the Booker dinner in 1997, Callil appeared on TV to denounce an Indian author's book as "vulgar and execrable". The book, now acknowledged as an undefined masterpiece that went on to win the Booker Prize, was called *The God of Small Things* by a 37-year-old first-time Indian novelist, Arundhati Roy, who people then mostly recognised by her unruly curls and twinkly nose ring rather than her social activism. Many excuses, like it wasn't a good year for British and Commonwealth writing to that the Booker had become the last stop for mediocre works, had been made for why the panel headed by Gillian Beer chose a book among the 106 entries that refused to exoticify India, basing itself in an inconsequential village in Kerala and not really venturing out of it. Salman Rushdie had famously said, "The trouble with Arundhati is that she insists that India is an ordinary place." But Roy's ordinary India set extraordinary standards in Indian writing. It had started when Roy, an architect by education and then a screenplay writer who had also acted in a couple of films, decided to write a novel, between 9 am to 3 pm daily. In April 1996, Pankaj Mishra, then with Harper Collins,

called Roy in the dead of the night after reading her manuscript to tell her that was "astoundingly good." By May, the book was sold for over \$1million to 18 countries and in September, an Indian had won her first Booker. Many insist that her path was paved by the likes of V.S. Naipaul's *In A Free State* in 1971 and Rushdie's *Midnight's Children* in 1982, along with many others, such as Anita Desai, who made it to the shortlist but never clinched the prize. But none can match what Roy's book did for the cause of Indian writing. The dam had broken. In subsequent years, Kiran Desai's *The Inheritance of Loss* in 2006 and Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger* in 2008 were milestones on the path she had beaten. Everything followed in her wake, be it young 20-something writers clogging bookshelves by the dozen or every Indian book making it to the shortlist of global literary prizes, including Jhumpa Lahiri's proud Pulitzer win, *The Interpreter of Maladies* in 1999. Roy's next, eagerly awaited, is the second novel she has embarked on after 12 years of promising that the only fiction in her was *The God of Small Things*. It's definitely going to be worth the wait.

by Swagata Sen

THE MAIN EVENT

Stock Market Falls

Talk about mood swings. On January 15, bullish buying by a group of smart operators pushed the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) Sensex to 3,647 points—an increase of 154 points in a single day. The volume of total trade at Rs 1,193 crore was the highest in BSE's history. A day later on the 16th, the Sensex plunged by 357 points after touching the day's high of 3,812 points, yet another record—the steepest plunge to be recorded in the exchange's history. Indeed, the bourses confounded market pundits and drove the regulator and chiefs of stock exchanges to increase vigilance on the operators, in the process preventing another wild bull run based on speculative sentiments. Says M.G. Damani, BSE president: "We have to do this because people seem to have stopped taking a long-term view." That the buying was essentially speculative reflects in the fact that deliveries were only 10 per cent, on an average, of the turnover on both the BSE and the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in the period of frenzy, with the rest of the trading getting squared-off during the settlements. *India Today*, Feb. 15, 1997

ALSO

- Mahesh Bhupathi becomes the first Indian to win a Grand Slam title
- Kalpana Chawla becomes the first Indian woman to go into space
- The Prasar Bharati Act comes into force

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Makeovers

Rekha Shedding her extra pounds of *Sawan Bhadon*, she emerged in chiffons and long flowing hair in *Silsila*.

Sridevi Over-the-top garish make-up and dresses gave way to nymph-like *Chandni*, ethereal in white.

Saif Ali Khan *Aashiq Awara*'s lanky lad with scraggly hair caught attention with his uber cool avatar in *Dil Chahta Hai*.

Karisma Kapoor No more bubblegum wardrobe or bushy brows. A style maven was born in *Raja Hindustani*.

Amitabh Bachchan Giving up his clean-shaven looks, the salt goatee and pepper hair became his signature style.